Customer Escalation Policy

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Summary. Defines the five customer escalation levels, automatic and customer-requested escalation triggers, roles, recording rules in NorthAssist, communication duties during escalations, de-escalation, and the coordination with Engineering incident management at Northstar Systems.

SYNTHETIC DOCUMENT - Northstar Systems is a fictional company. This document exists for development, testing and demonstration only and is not real legal, employment, security or compliance advice.

1. Purpose and Scope

This policy explains how Northstar Systems Private Limited escalates customer issues for the Northstar Nexus Platform, Nexus Connect and Nexus Insight. It tells Support Engineers, Support Leads, Customer Success Managers (CSMs), Engineering on-call managers and executives who must be involved, when they must be involved, and what each of them must do. Its aim is that no customer problem stays unresolved without senior attention, and that escalation is applied consistently regardless of which customer raises it.

The policy applies to every customer-facing case recorded in NorthAssist (the customer support ticketing and portal system), whatever the customer's support tier (Standard, Premier or Enterprise) and whatever the priority (P1 Critical, P2 High, P3 Medium, P4 Low). It covers escalations triggered by time, by customer request, by commercial risk and by Engineering incidents. It does not describe how Engineering runs the technical response to a production incident; that is covered by ENG-004 (Production Incident Management Procedure) and ENG-005 (On-Call and Escalation Handbook). Priority definitions, response targets and credits are set in CS-003 (Service-Level Objectives and Support Procedures), and customer messaging rules are in CS-005 (Customer Communication Standards).

2. Definitions

- **Escalation**: the controlled transfer of ownership or visibility of a case to a more senior level, so that more authority or expertise is applied.
- **Functional escalation**: bringing in a technical specialist (for example Engineering) without changing who owns the customer relationship on the case.
- **Hierarchical escalation**: raising the case to the next management level because of time, impact or customer dissatisfaction.

- **Priority (P1 to P4)**: the customer-facing severity of a case. P1 Critical means production is down or data is at risk. P2 High means a major feature is impaired. P3 Medium means partial impairment with a workaround. P4 Low means a question or cosmetic issue.
- **Severity (SEV1 to SEV4)**: the internal Engineering classification of a production incident. A P1 case may or may not correspond to a SEV1 incident; the link is described in section 9.
- **Case owner**: the person accountable for the customer case at the current level, recorded in NorthAssist.
- **Reason code**: the mandatory NorthAssist field that records why an escalation was made.
- **Executive sponsor**: the CEO, who acts as the sponsor for Enterprise customers only at Level 5.

3. Escalation Levels

Northstar uses five escalation levels. Every level has a named role, and the case owner at each level is accountable until the case is handed back or closed.

Level	Role	Typical responsibility
Level 1	Support Engineer	Triage, diagnosis, first response, workaround, regular updates
Level 2	Support Lead	Resource allocation, technical direction, customer call if needed
Level 3	Director of Customer Success or Engineering on-call manager	Cross-team action, Engineering engagement, commercial and service decisions
Level 4	VP Customer Success	Executive-level ownership, customer executive contact, recovery commitments
Level 5	CEO executive sponsor (Enterprise only)	Executive sponsorship for severe, prolonged or relationship-threatening situations

Level 3 is held by the Director of Customer Success when the main need is customer management and decisions, and by the Engineering on-call manager when the main need is technical resolution. When both are needed, both are engaged and the Director of Customer Success remains owner of the customer relationship while the Engineering on-call manager owns the technical response. Level 5 is available only to Enterprise-tier customers. A Standard or Premier customer whose case reaches Level 4 stays with the VP Customer Success; the CEO is not engaged unless the VP Customer Success and the CEO agree that an exceptional situation justifies it, which must be recorded with a reason code.

4. Automatic Escalation for P1 Cases

A P1 case that is not resolved escalates automatically by elapsed time since the P1 priority was confirmed. The clock runs 24x7 for Premier and Enterprise customers. For Standard customers the clock runs in business hours only, because Standard P1 coverage is business hours 9:00-19:00 IST Monday to Friday, excluding company holidays.

Time since P1 confirmed and unresolved	Escalates to
2 hours	Level 2 (Support Lead)

Time since P1 confirmed and unresolved	Escalates to
4 hours	Level 3 (Director of Customer Success or Engineering on-call manager)
8 hours	Level 4 (VP Customer Success)

The thresholds are the same for all tiers. NorthAssist raises an alert to the next level when a threshold is crossed. The receiving level must acknowledge the alert in NorthAssist; a level that does not acknowledge within 30 minutes causes a notification to the level above it. Automatic escalation does not remove the lower level from the case: the Support Engineer continues to work the case and send updates unless the Support Lead reassigns it.

Example: A Premier customer, a logistics company in Pune, reports at 02:10 IST that all Pipelines in its Nexus Workspace fail with NX-5000. The Support Engineer confirms P1 at 02:25. At 04:25 NorthAssist escalates to the Support Lead. At 06:25, still unresolved, it escalates to the Engineering on-call manager as Level 3, and the Director of Customer Success is informed. The target workaround time for a Premier P1 is 6 hours, so the Level 3 escalation at 4 hours leaves two hours to meet it.

P2 cases do not escalate automatically by time in the same way. Instead, if a P2 case has missed its update frequency twice in a row, or has been open past the resolution expectation agreed with the customer, the Support Lead must review it and decide whether to escalate to Level 3. P3 and P4 cases escalate only on request or for the reasons in section 6.

5. Customer-Requested Escalation

A customer may ask for escalation at any time, through the NorthAssist portal, by replying to the case email, or by telling their CSM or any Northstar employee. No customer should have to justify the request or be told it is unnecessary.

1 The employee who receives the request must record it in NorthAssist immediately, even if the customer expressed it informally, and select the reason code "customer requested".
2 The request must be acknowledged to the customer within 1 hour in business hours. The acknowledgement names the Level to which the case has been raised and the person who now owns it.
3 The Support Lead (Level 2) reviews the case within the same hour and decides whether it should go to Level 3. If the customer asks for a specific level, for example the Director, the request must be passed to that level and the decision to decline must be made by that level, not by a lower one.
4 The customer is told what will happen next and when they will next hear from Northstar.

A customer-requested escalation does not change the case priority. A P3 case remains P3 even if raised to Level 3; the priority changes only if the facts about impact change. If the customer believes the priority is wrong, the Support Lead must review the priority against the definitions in CS-003 and explain the outcome in writing.

Example: A Standard customer opens a P3 case about a Pipeline failing intermittently with NX-2004. After five business days with no resolution, the customer's operations manager emails the Support Lead asking for escalation. The Support Lead records the request, acknowledges it within 1 hour in business hours, reviews the case, brings in an Engineering engineer through functional escalation, and agrees an update on a daily basis until a cause is identified.

6. Other Escalation Triggers

Beyond time and customer request, a case must be escalated, at least to Level 2 and sometimes higher, in these situations.

- **Repeated failure**: the same issue has recurred three times in 30 days for the same customer. Escalate to Level 2 for a root cause review.
- **Data risk**: any suspicion of data loss, corruption or exposure. Escalate immediately to Level 3 and notify the Security Desk (ext. 5555 or security@northstar-systems.example). Personal-data matters are also reported to the Privacy Officer.
- **Commercial risk**: the customer states an intent to cancel or not renew, or the account health score is Red (see CS-008). Escalate to the CSM and the Director of Customer Success.
- **Legal or contractual language**: the customer cites legal action, penalties or a breach of contract. Escalate to Level 4 and inform the General Counsel before any written reply is sent.
- **Media or public attention**: the customer threatens public disclosure or the issue is visible on social channels. Escalate to Level 4 and inform the Head of Customer Communications.
- **Executive contact**: a customer executive contacts a Northstar executive about a case. The executive must route it to the VP Customer Success; the executive must not promise anything directly.
- **Conduct concern**: a customer or Northstar employee behaves unprofessionally. Escalate to the Support Lead, who will decide whether HR needs to be involved.

7. Roles and Responsibilities

7.1 Support Engineer (Level 1)

The Support Engineer owns the case from creation. They must triage and set priority within the first-response target in CS-003, collect the required ticket information (tenant ID, Workspace name, Nexus version, request ID, timestamp with timezone, steps to reproduce and impact statement), send updates at the required frequency, and record every escalation with its reason code. They must flag a case to the Support Lead early when they expect to miss a target rather than waiting for the automatic threshold.

7.2 Support Lead (Level 2)

The Support Lead assigns additional engineers, reviews diagnosis, decides whether Engineering must be engaged, and joins customer calls when needed. They own the daily review of all open P1 and P2 cases and all cases with an open customer-requested escalation. They must decide on promotion to Level 3 and record the decision.

7.3 Director of Customer Success or Engineering on-call manager (Level 3)

At Level 3 the Director of Customer Success owns customer decisions: service gestures within their authority, scheduling executive calls, agreeing recovery plans and approving non-standard commitments. The Engineering on-call manager owns the technical response: assigning engineers, authorising emergency changes under the process in ENG-004, and confirming any date or fix that may be communicated. No delivery date may be promised to a customer without Engineering confirmation.

7.4 VP Customer Success (Level 4)

The VP Customer Success owns the case at executive level. They contact the customer's executive, agree on a recovery or service-improvement plan, decide on exceptions, authorise

cross-department support, and decide whether Level 5 is appropriate for an Enterprise customer. They also receive the weekly summary of every Level 4 case until closure.

7.5 CEO executive sponsor (Level 5, Enterprise only)

The CEO acts as executive sponsor when an Enterprise customer relationship is at serious risk, such as a prolonged P1, repeated SEV1 incidents or a threatened termination. The sponsor does not run the technical response. They speak to the customer's senior leadership, confirm commitments made by the VP Customer Success and remove organisational blockers.

7.6 Customer Success Manager

The CSM stays the relationship contact throughout an escalation, keeps the customer's business stakeholders informed, and records the commercial and sentiment effects of the escalation in the account notes used for the health score in CS-008. The CSM must not diagnose technical causes in customer messages.

8. Recording Escalations in NorthAssist

Every escalation must be recorded in NorthAssist with a reason code at the time it happens. The record must show who escalated, who received it, the level, the time, and the reason. Allowed reason codes are: time threshold, customer requested, repeated failure, data risk, commercial risk, legal or contractual, public attention, executive contact, Engineering incident linked, and other (with free-text explanation). An escalation without a reason code is treated as incomplete, and the Support Lead must correct it within one business day.

NorthAssist records are the only authoritative source for escalation metrics. Verbal or chat-only escalations must be written into the case within 1 hour. The Head of Support reviews the escalation log monthly for patterns such as repeated escalations of the same customer, products or error codes, and shares the findings with Product and Engineering. Cases are retained as support tickets under the retention schedule, 5 years after closure.

9. Relationship with Engineering Incidents

A single customer case may be the first sign of a wider production incident. Equally, an Engineering incident declared internally affects many customer cases at once.

- When a Support Engineer suspects an issue affects more than one customer, or meets the definition of SEV1 (complete outage, data loss or corruption, or confirmed security breach affecting customers) or SEV2 (major degradation of a key feature or multiple customers), they must page the Engineering on-call using the process in ENG-005 and inform the Support Lead.
- Once Engineering declares a SEV1 or SEV2, a parent incident is created. All related customer cases must be linked to it in NorthAssist with the reason code "Engineering incident linked". Updates to customers should draw on the incident's status updates rather than each case being investigated separately.
- Northstar Status is updated within 30 minutes of declaring SEV1 or SEV2, and the first customer notification, including email to affected Enterprise and Premier contacts, is sent within the same 30 minutes, as set out in CS-005.
- The Incident Commander owns the technical response, and the Communications Lead on the incident works with the Support Lead and CSMs so that messages are consistent. Customer-facing escalation levels continue to apply to each linked case, but the Level 3 Engineering on-call manager is normally the Incident Commander's counterpart.

- After resolution, a blameless post-incident review is completed within 5 business days for SEV1 and SEV2, and a customer-facing root cause analysis (RCA) is provided to Enterprise and Premier customers within 5 business days of resolution; Standard customers receive it on request within 10 business days.

Example: At 11:40 IST three customers report slow Pipelines. The Support Lead sees all three have Nexus 5.0 LTS and are in the Mumbai region, and pages the Engineering on-call. Engineering declares SEV2 at 11:55. The three cases are linked to the incident, Northstar Status shows a notice by 12:25 at the latest, and the case owners send updates every 4 hours for P2 (every 2 hours for the Enterprise customer) using the incident's information.

10. Communication During Escalation

The following rules apply to every escalated case.

- The customer must be told who owns the case now and how to reach them.
- Updates must follow the priority update frequency: P1 every 60 minutes (Enterprise every 30 minutes), P2 every 4 hours (Enterprise every 2 hours), P3 every 2 business days, P4 weekly. If there is no new information, the update must say so and give the time of the next update.
- Messages must be plain, empathetic and free of blame, and must not name internal systems (for example NorthAssist or NorthDesk) or contain personal data.
- The language is English; Hindi is available on request for customers in India.
- No dates, fixes or credits may be promised without confirmation from Engineering (for dates and fixes) or the authorised approver (for credits).
- Internal discussions about the cause, blame or commercial strategy must stay in internal notes of the case and must never be copied to customer-visible fields.

11. De-escalation and Closure

An escalation is lifted only when the cause is addressed and the customer's concern is answered. The level that raised the escalation decides when to de-escalate, after agreeing with the customer that a workaround or fix is satisfactory. A de-escalation entry in NorthAssist must state the resolution, the customer's acknowledgement, and any follow-up actions with owners and dates. For Level 4 and Level 5 escalations, the VP Customer Success must hold a closure call or meeting with the customer within 10 business days of the fix. After closure, the CSM checks within 30 days that the problem has not recurred and records the result in the customer health review (see CS-008).

Example: After a 9-hour Enterprise P1, the case reached Level 4. The fix is deployed, the RCA is delivered in 4 business days, and the VP Customer Success meets the customer's CTO in week two. The CSM schedules a 30-day check and updates the account's health score inputs.

12. Exceptions and Edge Cases

- **Weekends and holidays**: P1 clocks for Premier and Enterprise continue running through weekends and company holidays. For Standard customers, the P1 clock pauses outside business hours and resumes when business hours begin.
- **Customer-caused delay**: when the case is waiting for information from the customer, the escalation clock pauses, provided the pause is recorded and the customer was clearly told what is needed. The Support Engineer must chase every business day. The clock restarts when the customer responds.

- **Third-party cause**: if the cause is outside Northstar's control (for example a customer's own endpoint or a third-party service), the case may still escalate by time. The case owner must explain the cause to the customer and offer a workaround if possible.
- **Conflict of interest**: a person who is directly involved in the cause of a case, such as the author of the change that triggered it, must not be the approver of the customer-facing response or credit.
- **Unreachable level**: if a level cannot be reached within 30 minutes, the next level above must be informed and may act in its place.
- **Abuse of escalation**: escalation is not a means to skip the queue. If a customer or employee repeatedly escalates cases that do not meet the criteria, the Support Lead should discuss the situation with the customer's CSM and, for employees, with their manager.
- **Service credits**: credits may follow an escalation but are decided under CS-003, and credits above INR 1,00,000 need Finance Controller approval.

13. Metrics and Review

The Head of Support reports monthly to the VP Customer Success on the number of escalations by level and reason code, the share of P1 cases that reached Level 3 or above, the time to acknowledge at each level, the number of customer-requested escalations, and repeat escalations by customer. The VP Customer Success reviews Level 4 and Level 5 cases quarterly with the Director of Customer Success and the Engineering on-call managers to find process or product improvements. The policy is reviewed every 12 months, or after any escalation where a threshold was missed with customer impact.

14. Related Documents

- CS-003, Service-Level Objectives and Support Procedures, for priorities, targets, update frequencies and service credits.
- CS-005, Customer Communication Standards, for customer messages, status updates and RCAs.
- CS-007, for supporting customer support guidance and knowledge base standards.
- ENG-004, Production Incident Management Procedure, and ENG-005, On-Call and Escalation Handbook, for the Engineering response.
- CS-008, Customer Health Score and QBR Process, for account health consequences of escalations.

15. Revision History

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2025-04-10	First release of the escalation policy
1.1	2025-10-15	Added automatic escalation thresholds and reason codes
1.2	2026-02-27	Clarified Level 5 scope, Engineering incident linkage and de-escalation rules